

₹7-10

LAKH

Average cost of an episode of a Hindi serial

₹2-3

LAKH

Episode cost for Tamil, Telugu or other regional language shows

₹1.5

LAKH

Cost of a 10-second ad in a top show on a leading Hindi channel

₹30-40

THOUSAND

Cost of a 10-second ad spot on regional channels

SOURCE INDUSTRY ESTIMATES



“Earlier, afternoon serials used to manage TRPs of 11-12. Now, primetime serials garner only 11-12, while afternoon shows get only 5”

S. RAMAMURTHY
MANAGING DIRECTOR,
VISION TIME



“In digital, you make entire seasons. You find out only when the show doesn’t get renewed for a second season that the first one did not work, maybe”

RAJAN SHAHI
FOUNDER,
DIRECTOR’S KUT PRODUCTIONS

tal-first strategy centred around aggressively scaling up its Jio-Cinema OTT app. Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd and Sony Pictures Networks India are in the midst of a proposed merger.

Shows are already facing the pinch as advertisers are taking their money to digital platforms. Vision Time’s Ramamurthy says 40 per cent of TV’s ad revenue has migrated to OTT players, YouTube and other social media. “That’s where the younger crowd is. In the future, TV ad spends will come down further. It may last for five years. But after that, the TV model may have to change.” Zenith’s Lala confirms a huge shift in ad spends, with TV ad spends growing in single digits when digital is witnessing 20-30 per cent growth. “Even in absolute numbers, TV and digital ad spends are almost equal. By 2024, digital will overtake TV in ad spends.” Basu says TV viewership is bound to be challenged by OTT as user penetration for OTT video in India is expected to increase from 30 per cent to 36 per cent between 2023 and 2027.

Now, seasoned producers, too, are flocking to web content. In Hindi, producers point to ‘TV+’ content such as *Gullak* (SonyLIV), which are 25-50-100-episode shows made on a budget of ₹30-50 lakh an episode for OTT platforms. They are the middle ground between a typical TV serial and expensive web originals like *Farzi* or *Family Man* that are shot on budgets of ₹3-3.5 crore per episode (excluding actor fee). Tewari says it is better to go in for these short-format shows rather than sign up for a 260-episode serial and risk losing money if it shuts down within 100 episodes. “Besides, the volume of business is the same whether you do 20 episodes on a budget of ₹35 lakh per episode or 100 episodes on a budget of ₹7 lakh per episode.”

Ramamurthy says his firm is working on eight TV serials now, compared to 14 a decade ago. Yarlagadda’s firm is focusing more on web shows, with four to five in various stages of development, while its serial count has dipped. “Serials barely turn in profits. For us, it just breaks even and meets certain parts of our office expenses.”

But OTT platforms haven’t cracked the profitability code just yet. Producers say it takes years for a show to get mooted on a top OTT platform. Shahi says the visibility of failure is higher on TV. “In digital, you make entire seasons. You find out only when the show doesn’t get renewed for a second season that the first one did not work, maybe.” Even as the TV versus OTT content debate rages on, producers say primetime TV serials are a diminishing phenomenon. Yarlagadda sees them making way for more non-fiction programming such as reality-, talk-, and game shows. “But the peak of the TV era is behind us.” **BT**

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